

SPOKES-PEOPLE



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League of American Bicyclists Releases 2013 Bicycle Friendly States Rankings

The League of American Bicyclists recently released their 2013 Bicycle Friendly States Rankings. Pennsylvania was ranked as the fifteenth most bicycle-friendly state, the same ranking as 2012, and the state plans to continue a focus on multi-modal transportation.

The criterion designated for ranking is based on a multifaceted Bicycle Friendly State (BFS) questionnaire answered by each state's Bicycle Coordinator. It is designed to establish best practices and illustrate general performance needs. The states that continue to promote bicycling and improve conditions can expect to improve their scores.

In 2010, Pennsylvania was ranked as 42nd in the country.

High scores were received in the education and encouragement categories, along with legislation, and enforcement, policy and programs. The categories where Pennsylvania received lower scores were infrastructure and planning and evaluation and planning.

PennDOT is encouraged by this ranking, but realizes that there is more work that needs to be done. Pennsylvania remains committed to ensuring the transportation system is accessible by all transportation modes, as demonstrated by Governor Tom Corbett's transportation funding proposal that includes a multi-modal fund. Corbett's plan would also create a Multi-Modal Deputate within PennDOT to demonstrate more interconnectivity among transportation modes.

To view and learn about the rankings, visit

<http://www.bikeleague.org/programs/bicyclefriendlyamerica/bicyclefriendlystate/rankings2013.php>.



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Pennsylvania Recognizes National Bike Month



PennDOT's Deputy Secretary for Highway Administration Scott Christie welcomed guests and provided opening remarks for the Spoke 'n Gear Expo following a group ride in observance of Bike to Work Day.

Pennsylvania joined states across the nation in recognizing May 2013 as National Bike Month, May 13 – 17 as Bike to Work Week and May 17 as Bike to Work Day.

“The increasing popularity of bicycle riding illustrates how important cycling is in a multi-modal transportation system,” said PennDOT Secretary Barry J. Schoch. “We encourage people to learn how to safely travel or commute by bicycle, which helps promote healthy lifestyles, increases tourism and reduces congestion on our highways.”

To recognize National Bike Month, volunteers from the Pennsylvania Department of Environmental Protection (DEP), Pennsylvania Department of Natural Resources (DCNR) and Pennsylvania Department of Transportation (PennDOT), invited commonwealth employees to ride their bikes to work during the week and celebrate National Ride to Work Day on Friday, May 17.

Bicycling in the ‘Big City’

By Wayne Mears, PennDOT Central Press Office

Alex Doty, executive director of the Bicycle Coalition of Greater Philadelphia, started commuting to work primarily by bicycle the late 90's. Since then, he has experienced the rewards and challenges of riding on two wheels in one of the country's largest cities.

Doty makes his four-mile commute, from west Philadelphia to the center city, on bicycle every month of the year. While he takes the trolley in extreme cold and rain, the majority of his mileage is logged on the Schuylkill River Trail and on bike lanes.

“How many times do you arrive at the office with a smile on your face because of an enjoyable commute?” Alex said in interview. “The commute home may be busy and intimidating at first, but I find it very gratifying buzzing by the folks sitting in traffic.”

When commuting by bicycle, commuters have to take storage space and attire into account. Doty

carries his lunch and other items in a saddle bag attached to the bike, preferring the bag to a back pack because of comfort and temperature fluctuations. Though Doty's ride is short enough that he doesn't have to shower after arriving at work, he keeps a clean set of clothes at the office just in case of unplanned events.

Parking is no concern, as Doty parks at a secure rack in the back of the building, and there is a bike corral on the street nearby.

Like other commuters, work and family commitments can sometimes impact Doty's schedule; however, this doesn't negatively affect his routine. A typical trip to Harrisburg starts with a ride to the 30th Street station where he locks up his bike and takes the train. Sometimes his daughter will need a ride, in which case he puts his bike on the bus rack and they ride the bus home together. In fact, riding is a family affair, with Doty's wife and 12-year-old son also commuting on bicycle.

While cost savings may have not been the driving force behind his decision to bike, he says it has saved him considerably. By not paying car expenses, Doty says he was able to save enough money to buy a home. When he does need a car, he uses a shared-car service; also, his commuting counts as his exercise so he doesn't have a gym membership.

Doty has advice for others who might be interested in commuting by bicycle. He suggests riding to work on a Saturday to find the best route without the fear of being late. After that, carefully choose a commuting route and consider different routes than might normally be considered.

Those who are new to bicycling or considering expanding their riding are encouraged to review the Pennsylvania Bicycle Driver's Manual at Traffic Safety Information Center at <http://www.justdrivepa.com>.

PennDOT Employee Receives National Trail Award

District 5 Safety Program Specialist & Bicycle/Pedestrian Coordinator Steve Pohowsky was recently recognized with the 2013 State Trail Worker Award from American Trails. This award is given to recognize an individual that has made outstanding contributions and provided continuing support to trail planning, development or maintenance.

In March 2003 Steve joined PennDOT as a Project Manager Assistant and transferred to Traffic Control Technician in 2004. He was promoted to his current position in 2006.

He works tirelessly making our transportation system safer for pedestrians and bikers, and maintains signage for the BicyclePA Route system in his area.



Steve was presented the award by Kurt Zwinkl, director of the Schuylkill River National & State Heritage Area. Also pictured is Elissa Garofalo, Executive Director of the Delaware & Lehigh National Heritage Corridor Inc.



Steve enjoys riding the trails on his recumbent tricycle.

He also is responsible for all Shared Use Path Trail Crossing Agreements and trail crossing design reviews and has worked on the Saucon Rail Trail, Union Canal Trail, Schuylkill River Trail, D&L Trail, Palmer Township Trail and several others.

If you frequent the trails in Eastern part of our state you may someday spot Steve cruising down the trail on his bicycle or his recumbent tricycle, which resembles a lawn chair on wheels. For more information on the award, visit <http://americantrails.org/awards/2013awards/PA-Stephen-Pohowsky-worker13.html>.

The following Letter to the Editor appeared in the Erie Times-News on April 1, 2013.

PennDOT lauded for response

I would like to thank the Pennsylvania Department of Transportation for addressing my concern. Earlier this winter, I made a request that the road shoulders on West Lake Road be cleared for pedestrians and cyclists. I received a call within a few hours to discuss my concern and was informed of PennDOT's procedures for clearing this road.

I was informed that the shoulders aren't a priority on the first pass, but they make attempts to clear them on subsequent passes. He also said he would pass this along to the appropriate people.

The next time it snowed, I noticed that the shoulders were noticeably clearer, and in the evening they were almost completely cleared. The clearing of the shoulders has been repeated several times since then, and has made my route to work much easier and safer.

So again, I would like to thank them for listening to and addressing my concern. This has made it safer for pedestrians and cyclists who use the route.

Tom Chandler, Millcreek Township

PennDOT Lends a Hand with Lititz to Ephrata Rail Trail Underpass

By Mike Domin, AICP, Lancaster County Planning Commission

A recreation trail on the former Reading & Columbia Railroad Line has long been a dream of communities that host this abandoned corridor in the north-central section of Lancaster County. Lititz Borough, Warwick Township, Ephrata Township, Akron Borough and Ephrata Borough have worked together for nearly a decade to repurpose the old freight line and turn it into a community asset.



Photo courtesy of Ephrata Borough



Photo courtesy of the ELA Group, Inc.

Though only a small amount of the trail has been constructed, a considerable amount of time and money has been spent getting the remaining sections of the trail ready for development. So when PennDOT announced plans to replace a deteriorating bridge on Rt. 272 that ran above the abandoned rail line in southern Ephrata Borough, concerns about the future completion of the trail quickly arose. Filling in the old railroad cut and building the new bridge on the fill would essentially sever the trail.

Much to the delight of the trail supporters, PennDOT approached Ephrata Borough early in the planning process with a design that incorporated a trail culvert or “underpass” into the new bridge project. Best of all, PennDOT proposed building and paying for the new underpass as part of the bridge replacement project.

Both the bridge and the trail underpass are currently under construction and should be completed by the end of June.

Kudos to PennDOT for recognizing the importance of the trail project to these communities!

*Originally published in the E-Newsletter of the Lancaster County Planning Commission, April 2013.

SAVE THIS DATE

SEPTEMBER 15-17, 2013

Greenways and Trails Summit: Making Connections

Local Hosts:

Oil Region Alliance of Business,
Industry and Tourism
Council on Greenways and Trails

Location:

Quality Inn & Conference Center,
Franklin



Council on
Greenways & Trails



PennDOT Now on YouTube

PennDOT recently launched a YouTube channel, www.youtube.com/PennsylvaniaDOT, to expand its public outreach on safety and education initiatives, as well as department operations.

The department's Pennsylvania Safe Routes to School five-video series on bicycle safety is included on the channel.

The channel expands PennDOT's existing social media outreach.

To interact with PennDOT on Facebook visit www.facebook.com/pennsylvaniadepartmentoftransportation and find PennDOT on Twitter at www.Twitter.com/PennDOTNews.



Heritage Rail Trail County Park

For the past 16 years, I have had the pleasure of working for the York County Rail Trail Authority, first as its project coordinator as the Heritage Rail Trail County Park was being completed into York City and now as its executive director as we develop other rail trails across York County. During that time, I watched this rail trail transform from a little-known, stone pathway to a regional destination. I am amazed by the Heritage Rail Trail's growing visitorship and economic benefits to York County. And in retrospect, I am equally amazed when I consider the leadership shown by our County's elected officials in the late 1980s, as they seized upon an opportunity to buy a railroad line at a time when most people had never heard of a rail trail.

Development of the Heritage Rail Trail County Park is truly a 'Cinderella' story, with many events and opportunities falling into place. First was the demise of the Northern Central Railway. These historic rails suffered from the rise in popularity of the automobile, then the bankruptcy of the Penn Central Transportation Company, and finally the wrath of Hurricane Agnes in 1972. Reconstruction of one set of rails began in 1973, when PennDOT assumed ownership of the rail line from York City to the MD-PA border. As it became clear that the second set of rails would not be brought back into service, the vision of a rail-with-trail grew. When ownership of 18.5-miles of rail line was transferred from PennDOT to the County of York in 1990, the stage was set for formation of the York County Rail Trail Authority and for development of the Heritage Rail Trail.



Senior Bikers on Heritage Rail Trail.



New Freedom Station with Customers, family biking on HRT.

The second opportunity in this 'Cinderella' story was the federal transportation funding that became available in the 1990s, known as ISTEA, and administered in Pennsylvania by the Department of Transportation. Two awards for rail trail development totaling over \$1 million and another award of nearly \$.5 million for restoration of historic rail structures propelled the project forward, and the Heritage Rail Trail opened to the public in August 1999.

Soon after the completion of the Heritage Rail Trail, it became apparent that the Rail Trail was not 'your ordinary park!' User surveys conducted in 1999, 2001, 2004, 2007 and 2012 revealed that the Heritage Rail Trail was drawing visitors from a wide geographic area and bringing increasing economic benefits to the county. According to the 2012 User Survey and Economic Impact Study done by the Rails to Trails Conservancy and the Heritage Rail Trail, the Heritage Rail Trail receives nearly 300,000 annual visitations and generates over \$4.4 million to the local economy, nearly 32 percent coming from outside York County.

Sustaining a facility of this type requires a certain operational expertise, which leads us to the final opportunity in this 'Cinderella' story. From the time the county assumed ownership of the rail line, the Heritage Rail Trail was destined to be a county park. The York County Department of Parks & Recreation oversees the management, maintenance, and security for the corridor as one of eleven county parks. Under their expert care, the Heritage Rail Trail has endured several hurricanes, while continuing to be improved with park benches, interpretive signage, parking facilities, train museums, and even educational programs for all ages.

See Trail Spotlight on page 6

While numerous non-profits host long-distance, off-road 'thons' on the Heritage Rail Trail as major fund-raisers, the corridor also serves as a portion of State Bicycle Route J.

Nevertheless, on any given day, a visit to the Heritage Rail Trail offers quiet, tranquil moments for visitors to relax and re-charge. Beginning in York City's historic district, visitors can experience restaurants, museums, and shops as well as nearby Sovereign Bank Stadium and Central Market. Traveling south along the Codorus Creek, the visitor passes through woods and farmland before reaching its mid-point at Hanover Junction Train Station. From here the corridor passes through the small communities of Glen Rock, Railroad, and New Freedom, which once owed their existence to the industries that grew up around the

railroad and today offer trail travelers nearby restaurants, community festivals, and even an outdoor farmers market during the summer months. Just south of New Freedom the Heritage Rail Trail makes a seamless connection with the Torrey C. Brown Trail (formerly the NCR Trail) and continues for another 21 miles before ending near Hunt Valley, MD.

Whether you are looking for an alternative bike route to work and a quick breakfast, a fitness work-out and a power drink, a quiet walk and a picnic, or a self-guided tour through Civil War era history and a full-course meal, the Heritage Rail Trail has it all---just waiting for you! Information can be found at www.yorkcountyparks.org and www.yorkpa.org.

By, Vanyla Tierney, Recreation Planner, PA Department of Conservation & Natural Resources



Prior to PennDOT's assumption of ownership in 1973 there were two sets of rails.

Pa. Trails Advisory Committee Releases 2012 Annual Report

Shining a light on their work on Pennsylvania's trails, the Pennsylvania Trails Advisory Committee has released their 2012 Annual Report outlining their major accomplishments on more than 50 trails throughout Pennsylvania. These projects represent significant undertakings in trail planning, development, construction, maintenance and promotion.

The report also highlights: the construction of 74 miles of new trails; bridges that were built; improved trail access; the organization of trail work crews; numerous trail tours and sojourns offered; the creation of user-friendly mobile apps and web resources; videos about PA trails published on YouTube; and trail signage developed.

The 20-member advisory committee was established in 2012 and, in coordination with the Department of Conservation of Natural Resources, continues to work toward their goal of constructing a trail in every community throughout Pennsylvania. The annual report can be downloaded at <http://www.dcnr.state.pa.us/brc/recreation/trails/index.htm>.

For more information please visit www.paoutdoorrecplan.com and www.ExplorePATrails.com.